

The Eiffel Tower

The Eiffel Tower is a wrought-iron lattice tower on the Champ de Mars in Paris, France. It is named after the engineer Gustave Eiffel, whose company Compagnie des Établissements Eiffel designed and built the tower between 1887 and 1889.

The tower was the entrance arch for the 1889 Exposition Universelle (World's Fair), held to celebrate the 100th anniversary of the French Revolution. It was originally 312 metres tall; with later additions of antennas it now stands 330 metres.

The chief engineers were Maurice Koechlin and Émile Nouguier, who conceived the design in 1884. The architect Stephen Sauvestre added decorative arches and a glass pavilion. Eiffel initially rejected the design but later championed it.

The tower was originally intended to stand for 20 years and be dismantled in 1909. It was saved because its height made it valuable for radio telegraphy. The French military used it to intercept German radio messages during World War I, and it became part of the French broadcasting network.

The tower is painted every seven years, requiring about 60 tonnes of paint. It is the most-visited paid monument in the world: about 7 million people ascend it each year. The tower has 1,665 steps to the top, though visitors can only climb to the second floor (674 steps).